



A NEW WORLD: Lahore's Anarkali Bazaar (left); preparations in full swing for the festival (below)

in Bangalore by 11:30 p.m., in Mumbai by 12:20 a.m. and in Delhi by 1:30 in the night, in Lahore there are no deadlines. Walking down M.M. Alam Road in the upmarket Gulberg, you can enter Pizza Hut at 1.15 a.m. and find the restaurant buzzing not just with locals but some foreign tourists as well. Restaurants, departmental stores and ice cream parlours are open till the wee hours of the morning.

One thing most visible here is the obvious Americanisation of Pakistan. With Dunkin' Donuts, Subway sandwiches, Nando's and McDonald's dotting the landscape, one is not surprised by the Yankee accent sported

by students who have never been abroad. Walk into SmokeGun, a restaurant conceptualised on the Wild West theme and you will see waiters dressed as peanut chomping cowboys, which harks back to the theme bars of the US. With tiny television sets at each table, we manage to catch the last few overs as India beat Pakistan in Delhi. With a victory firmly sealed, albeit on the cricket field, we make our way to the exit. At the billing counter the manager enquires if we are from India. Something about the way we were talking must have given us away. With a victory over our hearts this time, he says, "Please take your seats, dessert is on the house, be our guests."

Surprising as it may sound, Lahoris are second to none in hospitality. It might be 60 years since the borders were drawn up dividing Punjab into two, but in Lahore there is a visible nostalgia and sentimentality about people across that illusory line—some auto-drivers actually have to be coerced into accepting money from Indians. There is a sizeable population of Sikhs in Lahore. Christians and Hindus are in minority, says the marketing manager of Tulip Hotel where the Indian delegates to the festival are housed. "I visited Delhi and Agra two years ago, but now it's impossible to get a visa," says

second year student at the Lahore University, Mohammad Raza. "Is Mumbai as glamorous as it appears in the films?" This is a question all Indians are routinely bombarded with, in Lahore. Indian film stars rule the DVD stores. The attendant who serves tea at the festival camp is deeply offended when he finds out that most of the Indian artistes have neither seen *Sawaariya* nor *Om Shanti Om*. "Kaise Indian *hain aap?*," he asks.

Does it mean that Emergency has had no impact on Pakistan? Not true as Lahore has the largest number of universities and the students are at the forefront of the agitation. What is surprising is that Musharraf continues to be respected though his dictatorial stand is not. "What are our

options—Benazir Bhutto, whom the people hate or Nawaz Sharif?" asks Shahid Omer, 24, writer and wholesale cloth merchant.

"Pakistan's geography is such that we cannot avoid the war on terror. We've been involuntarily swept into the ensuing turmoil. As a result, all participating countries in the festival

will most likely experience the effects of Pakistan's political crisis. Of more significance, though, is the fact that they will experience the real purpose and drive of a city that has such dynamic culture and history," says Faizaan Peerzada, one of the festival directors.

As one walks down Gwal Mandi, the food street near Anarkali (the tombs of Anarkali, Salim a.k.a. Jehangir and Noor Jehan are located in Lahore), or watches the gurdwara next to the Badshahi Masjid (the largest single-unit mosque in the world, modelled on the lines of the Jama Masjid in Delhi), it's difficult to imagine that Emergency has been imposed in this country, till a note is quietly slipped into one's hands at the corner of the street near the Gaddafi Stadium, which reads, "Your silence: the death of our country. If not now, when? If not us, who? Silence is consent, speak", while inside the festival enclosure Sufi singer Sain Zahoor chants "*Allah ho*", sending listeners into a trance. ■

Pakistan has been Americanised, with students who have never been abroad sporting a Yankee accent

CULTURE



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me what to do and not do, nor do I want someone telling my daughter to wear a burqa. Musharraf is not just fighting some militants, he's also fighting fundamentalists," says artist Usmaan Peerzada, 51, who is also the CEO of the World Performing Arts Festival.

Burgas and veils are other stereotypes that do not match the reality. You are likely to find more women in burgas in Delhi than in Lahore. And, here is the best part. While you are sure to be shooed out of a restaurant